Proceedings of the International Symposium on Soil Health and Sustainable Crop Production

Volume 1

Edited by

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A demonstrative volume prepared as a LaTeX benchmark asset.

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Nature of this volume. This volume is a demonstrative publication prepared as a LaTeX benchmark asset. The symposium is fictional. The contributed papers, their field trials, sites and datasets are synthetic: every measurement is generated by a seeded computer program supplied with the asset, and no value reports an experiment carried out on real land. The papers cite real published literature for methods, definitions and context; those works are cited, not reproduced. The results in this volume must not be used as evidence about real soils, crops or farming systems.

Conventions. Quantities are given in SI units. Grain and biomass yields are expressed in $\mathrm{t\,ha^{-1}}$ on a dry-matter basis unless stated otherwise, soil organic carbon in $\mathrm{g\,kg^{-1}}$, and soil pH is measured in water at a soil-to-solution ratio of 1:2.5.

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Contents

Editor's Preface **v**

How This Volume Is Organised **vii**

1 Selecting a Minimum Dataset of Soil Health Indicators for Mixed Cropping Systems **1**
1.1 Introduction 1

2 Maize Yield Response to Nitrogen Rate and Nitrogen Use Efficiency **3**
2.1 Introduction 3

3 Maize–Cowpea Intercropping and the Land Equivalent Ratio **5**
3.1 Introduction 5

4 Tillage and Residue Management Effects on Soil Organic Carbon and Yield **7**
4.1 Introduction 7

5 Organic Amendments and the Stabilisation of Soil Organic Carbon **9**
5.1 Introduction 9

6 Designing and Analysing Multi-Site Field Trials for Soil Health Research **11**
6.1 Introduction 11

Editor's Preface

Soil is the foundation of crop production, yet its condition changes slowly and is easily overlooked until yields begin to fall. The idea of soil health treats the soil as a living system whose chemical, physical and biological properties together decide how well it supports crops, stores water and carbon, and recovers from disturbance. Measuring that condition, and managing land so that it improves rather than declines, is a shared concern of agronomists, soil scientists and farmers in every climatic zone.

This volume brings together six contributed papers presented at the International Symposium on Soil Health and Sustainable Crop Production. They were chosen to span the main questions of the field: how soil health is indicated and measured, how nutrients and organic matter are managed, how crops respond to different systems of tillage, intercropping and rotation, and how results from field trials are analysed and reported. Each paper is self-contained, with its own abstract and list of references, and each can be read and typeset on its own.

All trial data in this volume are synthetic, as the imprint explains. They were designed to behave like realistic field measurements and to obey the rules set out in the methods of each paper, so that the volume can serve as a faithful example of how such work is written, checked and published.

Rotimi Alade
Editor

How This Volume Is Organised

Structure

The volume is divided into three parts. The front matter contains the title pages, the contents, the editor's preface and this note. The main matter contains the six contributed papers, one chapter each. The back matter contains the list of abbreviations and the subject index.

The papers

Each paper opens with its title, a short title used in the running head, and an abstract. It then follows the usual order of a research paper: introduction, materials and methods, results, discussion and conclusion. References are listed at the end of each paper rather than collected at the end of the volume, so that every paper can be cited and read on its own.

Data, tables and figures

The data behind every table and figure are stored with the volume as tab-separated files. Figures are drawn directly from those files when the volume is typeset, and values quoted in the text are computed from the same data, so text, tables and figures cannot disagree with one another.

Abbreviations and index

Abbreviations are spelled out at their first use in each paper and are listed together in the back matter. The subject index points to the pages on which the main concepts, methods and measured properties are discussed.

Paper 1

Selecting a Minimum Dataset of Soil Health Indicators for Mixed Cropping Systems

Contributed paper

Abstract. Soil health cannot be measured directly; it has to be inferred from a small number of soil properties that respond to management and that relate to the functions a farmer depends on. This paper describes how a minimum dataset of six indicators was chosen for a multi-site trial network covering three climatic zones, how each indicator is converted to a common score between 0 and 1, and how the scores are combined into a single soil health index. The dataset spans chemical, physical and biological properties so that no single group of processes dominates the index. The approach is applied to synthetic trial data and is intended as a worked example of indicator selection and scoring, not as a recommendation for any real location.

Keywords: soil health; soil quality; minimum dataset; indicator scoring; soil health index

1.1 Introduction

Interest in the condition of agricultural soils has grown steadily since soil quality was defined as the capacity of a soil to function within ecosystem boundaries, sustaining biological productivity, environmental quality and plant and animal health (Karlen et al. 1997). The term *soil health* places more weight on the soil as a living system, and on the organisms whose activity drives nutrient cycling and the formation of soil structure (Doran and Zeiss 2000). The two terms are now often used interchangeably, although the concept of soil health has broadened to include links with human health and with the services that soils provide beyond the farm (Lehmann et al. 2020).

Because soil health is a property of the whole system, it cannot be read from a single instrument. It is inferred instead from indicators: measurable soil properties that are sensitive to management, related to a soil function, and practical to measure. The number of candidate indicators is large, and a review of assessment schemes found that the choice between them, and the way measured values are interpreted, is still inconsistent from one programme to the next (Bünemann et al. 2018). A common response is to select a *minimum dataset*, the smallest set of indicators that together describe the functions of interest without redundancy.

Selecting indicators is only the first of three steps. Each measured value must then be interpreted, usually by transforming it to a unitless score that expresses how well the soil performs relative to a target, and the scores must finally be combined into an index. The Soil Management Assessment Framework formalised these three steps and showed that scoring curves which rise, fall or peak with the measured value can represent the different ways in which an indicator relates to soil function (Andrews et al. 2004).

This paper applies the same three steps to the trial network used throughout this volume. Its aims are to state the criteria by which six indicators were chosen, to define the scoring function for each, and to show how the resulting index is calculated, so that the later papers can report soil health on a common basis. Soil organic carbon is determined by wet oxidation (Walkley and Black 1934) and extractable phosphorus by the Mehlich 3 method (Mehlich 1984); the remaining indicators and all laboratory procedures are described under Materials and Methods.

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Paper 2

Maize Yield Response to Nitrogen Rate and Nitrogen Use Efficiency

Contributed paper

Abstract. Nitrogen is the nutrient that most often limits cereal yields, yet a large share of the nitrogen applied as fertiliser is not taken up by the crop. This paper reports a nitrogen rate trial in maize with five rates of mineral nitrogen, repeated at three sites in contrasting climatic zones. Grain yield is related to the rate applied through a response function, from which an agronomic optimum rate is derived, and the efficiency with which applied nitrogen is converted to grain is expressed through standard efficiency measures calculated against an unfertilised control. The trial data are synthetic and serve to illustrate how rate response and nitrogen use efficiency are calculated and reported.

Keywords: maize; nitrogen fertiliser; rate response; agronomic efficiency; nitrogen use efficiency

2.1 Introduction

Cereal production depends heavily on fertiliser nitrogen, and the efficiency with which that nitrogen is used has become a central question for both farm profitability and the environment. Reviews of cereal systems have shown that the fraction of applied nitrogen recovered by the crop is often low, and that the nitrogen not taken up is at risk of loss to water and air (Cassman et al. 2002). Improving efficiency therefore depends on matching the supply of nitrogen, in amount and timing, to the demand of the crop.

A retrospective analysis of fertiliser nitrogen in cereal production found that recovery efficiencies measured in farmers' fields are commonly lower than those achieved on research stations, and that the gap reflects both management and the variable nitrogen supply of the soil itself (Ladha et al. 2005). Nitrogen use efficiency is not a single number: it can be expressed as the extra grain produced per unit of nitrogen applied, as the fraction of applied nitrogen taken up by the crop, or as the grain produced per unit of nitrogen taken up, and each measure answers a different question.

Rate trials remain the basic tool for describing how a crop responds to nitrogen. Yield rises steeply at low rates, more slowly at intermediate rates, and reaches a plateau once nitrogen no longer limits growth. Fitting a response function to the yields allows the rate at which the marginal return falls to zero to be estimated, and comparison with an unfertilised control allows the efficiency measures to be calculated. Such trials are usually laid out as randomised complete blocks, which control for gradients in soil fertility across the field (Gomez and Gomez 1984).

Fertiliser is most effective when it is used together with organic inputs and well-adapted varieties, an approach set out as integrated soil fertility management (Vanlauwe et al. 2010). This paper reports the mineral nitrogen component of such a system. Its aims are to describe the yield response of maize to five rates of nitrogen at three sites, to estimate the agronomic optimum rate at each site, and to report the agronomic efficiency of applied nitrogen across rates and sites.

References

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Paper 3

Maize–Cowpea Intercropping and the Land Equivalent Ratio

Contributed paper

Abstract. Growing a cereal and a legume together on the same land can produce more in total than growing each crop alone on the same area. This paper compares maize and cowpea grown as sole crops with the two crops grown together in alternating rows, at three sites. The advantage of the intercrop is measured by the land equivalent ratio, calculated from the intercrop yield of each species relative to its sole-crop yield, and the contribution of each crop to the combined advantage is reported through its partial ratio. All yields are synthetic; the paper demonstrates how the land equivalent ratio is calculated, tabulated and interpreted.

Keywords: intercropping; maize; cowpea; land equivalent ratio; cereal–legume systems

3.1 Introduction

Intercropping, the growing of two or more crops together for at least part of their life cycle, is an old practice that remains widespread in low-input farming systems. It has attracted renewed interest because it can raise total production without additional inputs, or make production more stable, and so offers one route towards the sustainable intensification of agriculture (Brooker et al. 2015). The advantage arises when the component crops use resources in complementary ways, for example by rooting at different depths, by drawing on light at different times, or, in the case of a legume, by fixing atmospheric nitrogen that the cereal would otherwise have to take from the soil.

Comparing an intercrop with sole crops is not straightforward, because the intercrop produces two harvests while each sole crop produces one. The land equivalent ratio resolves this by asking how much land would be needed under sole cropping to produce the yields obtained from one unit of land under intercropping. It is the sum, over the component crops, of the intercrop yield of each crop divided by its sole-crop yield (Mead and Willey 1980). A ratio greater than one shows that the intercrop uses land more efficiently than the sole crops; a ratio of 1.2, for example, means that 20 per cent more land would be needed to match the intercrop by growing the crops separately.

The value of the ratio depends on the sole-crop yields used to standardise it, and the choice of those yields must be stated when results are reported (Mead and Willey 1980). In this trial each sole crop is grown in the same blocks as the intercrop, so that the standardising yields

come from the same site, season and management. Cereal–legume combinations are also a component of integrated soil fertility management, in which legumes contribute to the nitrogen economy of the following cereal (Vanlauwe et al. 2010).

The aims of this paper are to report the sole-crop and intercrop yields of maize and cowpea at three sites, to calculate the partial and total land equivalent ratios, and to identify the sites at which the intercrop gives a yield advantage.

References

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Paper 4

Tillage and Residue Management Effects on Soil Organic Carbon and Yield

Contributed paper

Abstract. Reduced tillage and the retention of crop residues are promoted to protect soils and build soil organic carbon, but their effect on crop yield varies with climate and management. This paper reports a factorial trial combining two tillage systems, conventional and no-till, with two residue treatments, removed and retained, at three sites. Soil organic carbon in the topsoil is compared with its value at the start of the trial, and grain yield is compared across the four combinations. The data are synthetic; the paper shows how a two-factor trial is analysed and how changes in soil organic carbon are reported alongside yield.

Keywords: conservation agriculture; no-till; crop residues; soil organic carbon; factorial trial

4.1 Introduction

Soil organic carbon lies at the centre of soil health. It supports soil structure, water retention and nutrient supply, and agricultural soils that have lost carbon through cultivation have a large capacity to regain it. Practices that increase the soil carbon pool include reduced tillage, the retention of residues, cover crops and the addition of manures, and the resulting gains in soil carbon can support higher crop yields on degraded land (Lal 2004).

Conservation agriculture combines three principles: minimal soil disturbance, permanent soil cover and crop diversification. A global meta-analysis of paired yield observations found that no-till on its own tends to reduce yields relative to conventional tillage, but that the reduction is smallest when no-till is combined with residue retention and crop rotation, and that the combination can raise rainfed yields in dry climates (Pittelkow et al. 2015). The yield effect of reduced tillage therefore depends on whether the other principles are applied with it.

Whether these principles can be applied in practice is a separate question. In smallholder farming systems, crop residues are often needed as livestock feed, weeding without tillage can increase labour, and the evidence for benefits has been argued to be less consistent than its promotion suggests (Giller et al. 2009). Trials that separate the effect of tillage from the effect of residues help to show which part of the package produces which effect.

This paper reports such a trial. Soil organic carbon is determined by wet oxidation (Walkley and Black 1934). The aims are to estimate the separate and combined effects of tillage and residue management on topsoil organic carbon and on grain yield, and to test whether the effect of tillage depends on the residue treatment.

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Paper 5

Organic Amendments and the Stabilisation of Soil Organic Carbon

Contributed paper

Abstract. Adding organic materials to soil raises its carbon content, but only part of the added carbon remains in the soil for long. This paper compares three organic amendments, applied at equal rates of carbon, with an unamended control at three sites, and follows topsoil organic carbon over the course of the trial. The fraction of added carbon retained in the soil is calculated for each amendment, and the retention is related to soil texture through the clay content of each site. The data are synthetic and illustrate how carbon retention is calculated and how it can be interpreted in terms of the mechanisms that protect organic matter from decomposition.

Keywords: organic amendments; manure; compost; soil organic carbon; carbon retention; clay

5.1 Introduction

Organic amendments such as animal manure, compost and crop residues supply nutrients and add carbon to the soil. They are a core component of integrated soil fertility management, in which they are combined with fertiliser to raise the efficiency with which nutrients are used (Vanlauwe et al. 2010). Beyond their nutrient value they feed the soil organisms on which many soil functions depend (Doran and Zeiss 2000).

Most of the carbon in a fresh amendment is decomposed within a few seasons and returned to the atmosphere as carbon dioxide. The fraction that persists depends on how the remaining organic matter is protected. A review of the mechanisms concluded that the chemical resistance of organic compounds to decay is important only in the early stages of decomposition, and that long-term persistence depends instead on the physical inaccessibility of organic matter to decomposers and on its association with mineral surfaces (von Lützow et al. 2006).

Because organic matter is protected by association with silt and clay particles and by its occlusion within aggregates, soils differ in how much carbon they can stabilise, and the protective capacity of a soil sets an upper limit to the carbon it can hold in protected forms (Six et al. 2002). Soils with more clay would therefore be expected to retain a larger share of added carbon, while soils close to that upper limit would retain less of each new addition. These ideas have practical weight, because the carbon that agricultural soils could regain is considerable (Lal 2004).

The aims of this paper are to compare the gain in topsoil organic carbon under three amendments with that of an unamended control, to calculate the fraction of the added carbon retained under each amendment, and to examine whether retention is greater at sites with higher clay content.

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Paper 6

Designing and Analysing Multi-Site Field Trials for Soil Health Research

Contributed paper

Abstract. Field trials in soil health research are usually repeated across sites, because a treatment that works on one soil may fail on another. This paper describes the design shared by the trials reported in this volume: three sites in contrasting climatic zones, randomised complete blocks at each site, and a common set of soil and crop measurements. It sets out how each site is analysed on its own, how the sites are combined, and how the interaction between treatment and site is tested and interpreted. The paper serves as the methodological reference for the other contributions, and all example values are synthetic.

Keywords: field experiments; randomised complete block design; analysis of variance; multi-site trials; treatment by site interaction

6.1 Introduction

Agricultural field experiments must separate the effect of a treatment from the natural variation between plots. The randomised complete block design does so by grouping plots into blocks that are as uniform as possible, assigning every treatment once in each block, and randomising the order of treatments within blocks, so that differences between blocks can be removed from the experimental error (Gomez and Gomez 1984). It remains the most common design for trials on farms and research stations alike.

A single site, however, represents a single soil and climate. When the same experiment is repeated at several sites, the question of interest changes from whether a treatment has an effect to whether its effect is consistent. A treatment by site interaction indicates that the ranking or the size of treatment effects differs between sites, and such interactions are the rule rather than the exception in soil management research, as the variable response of crop yield to reduced tillage across climates illustrates (Pittelkow et al. 2015). Experiments conducted over space and time require their own methods of combined analysis (Gomez and Gomez 1984).

Soil health trials add a further difficulty, because the response is often described not by one variable but by several indicators that must be interpreted together. Converting indicators to a common score before they are combined, as in the Soil Management Assessment Framework (Andrews et al. 2004), makes results comparable across sites, and a clear statement of how indicators were chosen and interpreted is needed if results are to be used by land managers and policy makers (Bünemann et al. 2018).

This paper describes the design and analysis used across the volume. Its aims are to document the layout of the trials, to state the statistical model used at each site and across sites, and to set out the rules by which treatment effects are reported, so that the results of the other papers can be read on a common basis.

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